

Rye Country Day School
Model United Nations Conference I

April 18th, 2026



UN Women

The Equal Pay Act

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Letter from the Secretariat

Dear Delegates and Faculty Advisors,

We are honored and excited to invite you to the inaugural Rye Country Day School Model United Nations Conference (RCDSMUNC I), which will take place on Saturday, April 18th, 2026. RCDS is thrilled to have such an incredible group of students on campus, working together to find solutions to real world issues.

The Secretariat, along with our faculty advisor, Mr. Murray, have been working diligently over the past year to coordinate our first conference. Our goal for RCDSMUNC I is to inspire delegates to collaborate while developing their knowledge on impactful global problems.

Our three committees cover a variety of topics, including the ethics of AI in business, the Equal Pay Act, and the Cold War.

We encourage you all to reach out to your chairs with any questions or concerns, and we hope you have an amazing and engaging conference. Good luck!

Best,

Zara Khemlani, Kevin Neilinger, and Lillian Pereira

RCDSMUNC I Secretariat

Committee Description

Established in 2010 by the United Nations General Assembly, UN Women aims to improve the state of women's rights and gender equality across the globe while empowering women for a better future. Its foundation was introduced as a sect of the UN reform agenda, in which resources and mandates were unified for the purpose of bringing efficiency to progress. The committee itself draws from four prior UN bodies: DAW, INSTRAW, OSAGI, and UNIFEM. In bringing these groups and combining their focus, UN Women looks to solve the broader issue at hand by recognizing where these areas overlap and can work together.

The committee currently stands with 45 member states and works with various government partners, women's movements, and the private sector alongside their coordination with the United Nations. UN Women focuses on four main areas of development: leadership; economic empowerment; freedom from violence; and peace, security, & humanitarian action. These main goals have motivated various

strides when it comes to supporting women globally, specifically in the realms of member states and the UN system. As the committee has come to understand, gender equality proves beneficial in all areas of society, enhancing great potential in the social, economic, political, and environmental realms. The efforts and progress made by the committee centers on reducing inequality within the global population of women, supporting those that fall within other marginalized groups and meeting their respective needs.

UN Women builds upon actions already being made, enhancing developing plans or actions to ensure improvement regarding gender equality. One such example is the tracking and involvement with number 5 of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (gender equality) included in the 2030 agenda. The committee does an annual review of the progress, releasing their findings in the Gender Snapshot report, which outlines the overall progress of the agenda as a whole through a gender perspective. As of 2025, there has

been slow but steady progress, yet within every goal there is still a tremendous amount of work left to be done, motivating predictions that the goals will not be achieved by 2030. The 2025 Gender Snapshot also points out the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action — an agenda that would become the foundation for all further action

on gender equality unanimously agreed upon in the 4th World Conference on Women — recognizing the moment as a call to higher action. UN Women seeks to accelerate the progress on gender equality through building upon and reforming current systems, staying focused on the four main areas of development.

Background Information

Women have participated in the economy throughout history, however, much of their labor was informal, unpaid, or confined to the domestic sphere. Prior to industrialization, women mainly worked on household upkeep, agriculture, and family matters. The rise of the Industrial Revolution in the early 19th century would lead to the early expansion of external employment for women. The number of jobs available greatly increased and the low-skill required labor of factories made it quick and accessible. The growth of textile mills and other manufacturing industries created new opportunities for women.

However, despite these new economic opportunities, conventional gender roles reinforced domestic lifestyles. Many women were not employed under the widespread practice of the Cult of Domesticity, the ideology that a women's duty was to be nurturing and domestic as wives and mothers, whose true place was inside the home. This spread in the circa the British and American Industrial Revolutions as a way to re-establish rigid gender roles, primarily for white middle and upper class women.

Still, resistance to exploitative labor conditions and passivity to injustice emerged. In 1834–1836, the

Lowell “Mill Girls” were young women workers in Lowell Massachusetts who organized strikes when the wages were cut and the workplace conditions were poor. This was crucial to the momentum of the American labor movement through demonstrating the strength of unity and of women. Lilly Ledbetter’s lost Supreme Court case led to the Lilly Ledbetter Fair Pay Act of 2009 which eased filing deadlines to sue for pay discrimination. These, amongst many others, are milestones that have built the foundation for eliminating the gender pay gap.

Notably, wartimes have witnessed increased women’s participation in the labor force. British employment rates during World War I drastically increased from 23.6% to around 40%. Men left job vacancies as they served at war, leaving women to fill in for positions in manufacturing, transportation, and civil service. These times challenge traditional assumptions about gender and work, creating a unified sense of independence and reshaping perceptions of women’s contributions and capabilities.

There is a distinction to make: Equal legislation is primarily focused on eliminating discriminatory practices that affect similar roles. Closing the gender pay gap is about eliminating the difference in the average wage of men and the average wage of women in all roles. One of the earliest laws passed specifically intended to close the gender pay gap, globally, was in 1961 in Iceland. On January 1, 2018, Iceland became the first country to mandate companies to prove that they are paying men and women equally for the same work. No other countries have enforced a mandate, regardless of their equal pay policy. The European Union has pay transparency systems in place, but it is not as proactive or to the extent that Iceland has done.

There is little consistency and standardization addressing gender-based pay inequality. In the United States in 2018, *Rizo v. Fresno County Office of Education* determined that an employee's previous salary does not justify paying a woman less than a man. Yet, the same year, the U.S. The Department of

Labor's Office of Federal Contract Compliance Programs released a policy that allowed employers to self-determine wages.

Furthermore, this committee, UN Women, often experiences inadequate funding. This is an issue when the committee's financial support is requested by a Member State, as part of its responsibilities.

In solidarity and association with other movements like women's suffrage and anti-discrimination efforts—including based on race, religion, and sexuality—the fight for equal pay has gained great attention and continues to progress.

Current Situation

The United Nations promotes equal pay, having determined it to be an essential component of human rights. This act supports the development of gender inequality and the enhancement of various global systems.

Gender pay inequality is still systemically ingrained all over the world today due to unfounded notions of biologically determined male superiority and behavior; longstanding, normalized gender conventions; the Cult of Domesticity; the inclusion of these norms into the foundations of national legal systems; etc. From domestic services to street vending

and other informal jobs that are often outside the jurisdiction of labor laws and result in lower wages, the inequality in payment is perpetuated on a systemic level of belief, eventually leading to normalization of lower wages for women. Often, this is despite the fact that women statistically work more hours. The 2025 Gender Snapshot found that women spend 2.5 more hours than men on unpaid-care work. These patterns lead to the practice of gender discrimination in everyday life, including workplaces, schools, and other social spaces/institutions. Women continue to struggle to be respected for the work that

they do, or are seen as less capable than men. Misogynistic conceptions continue to be prevalent in many societies, despite their progress on women's rights.

Equal Pay Acts have been passed in various nations to different extents of parameters. With the lack of standardization or hard mandate, the gender pay gap continues to stand at approximately twenty percent in 2025. On top of this, much of this progress remains uneven. As per the 2025 Global Gender Gap Report, the average regional gender pay gaps across Africa and Asia fall below 69% — the lowest being the Middle East and Northern Africa with a score of 61.7% — in comparison to the roughly 75% close to the gap found in European and American areas. This disparity between progress is true to the current state of the situation, the pacing, and the unity across each region. While Latin America tends to progress as a whole, with the current range of scores being 8.4 in 2025, those numbers grow when looking into parts of Africa and Asia. With progress being highly concentrated to a portion of the world, there is a concern for equality within the issue of the gender pay gap for women

that fall into various ethnic and nationality groups. Setting a baseline for all nations to follow as they attempt to close the pay gap is a crucial part of tackling the issue at large.

Division also exists at a class level. High-income economies have a larger closing of the gender pay gap than middle- and lower-income areas, however low-income areas have a greater amount of specific areas that make tremendous amounts of progress in comparison to the majority of high-income regions. There is an advantage to be found within both ends of the spectrum, with wealthier regions having a better baseline/average, and poorer regions having extremely successful individual cases. Recognizing the successes in both and finding a medium between them allows for more unified and steady progression across the entire spectrum of regional income.

Looking further into the issue, four sub-index dimensions are noted: Economic Participation and Opportunity, Political Empowerment, Health and Survival, and Educational Attainment. The former two maintain a significantly greater gender gap, with a 61.0% economic close and a lagging 22.9% close politically in comparison to the

health and educational closes being 96.2% and 95.1% respectively. Due to this, most plans of action prioritize the former two, with both receiving significant progress in recent times, while the latter half stay more stagnant. It is important to continue progress when nearing a full close, rather than neglecting those parts of the issue in the face of more obvious ones. Economic and political uplifting is still greatly needed in comparison to health and education, yet pausing the work being done for any of these dimensions will prove no benefit for anyone. A well-rounded solution will recognize a weighted but fair separation of responsibility and resources without hindering the progress that has already been accomplished.

Pay equity — which is the specific focus on eliminating biases — is another large factor of the equation. Much progress can be made in all of the issues that go into the existence of the gender pay gap, but ensuring pay equity is necessary if that hopes to be maintained. Nations such as the UK, Germany, Iceland, and Peru have made

well-recognized amendments to their legislatures that have addressed the issue of discrimination in the working realm. Meanwhile, other nations, including France, Canada, Austria, and Australia are in the process passing similar laws. The push for advancements regarding the four sub-index dimensions shouldn't be for naught when it comes time to make use of them in the actual workplace. These laws are a necessary means to an end, as without pay equity there will never be a true close to the gender pay gap.

While there have been great strides in the fight for equal pay, issues of further inequality exist within the issue itself, concentrating advancements into specific regions or areas of development only further complicates the broader context, as it increases disparities and perpetuates a harmful standard. Unifying action to improve the overall state of the gender pay gap is crucial to an equitable and efficient solution.

Possible Solutions

The committee is gathering to review the Equal Pay Act and thoroughly examine what future actions to take regarding the Equal Pay Act and the gender pay gap.

Nations may choose to pioneer the Equal Pay Act through advocacy, supporting unions, and global standardization. They may also feel advised to enforce it strongly through mandated reports and audits of equal pay. The committee may also choose to consider each individual nation's situation

to determine the course of action that they should take in regards to the Equal Pay Act. When considering pay equity laws, the categories of workers included, the legal definition of remuneration, and the method of verifying comparisons of pay should be clarified. The committee may also create new jobs in government and government projects to increase women's employment rates and support higher income earning opportunities.

Delegate Positions

The 44 delegations below are listed, with their nation and a brief note of their current circumstance with the topic. All nations experience a degree of systemic misogyny, traditional gender roles working against gender income parity, and many nations have unaddressed motherhood penalties that create career interruptions.

1. **Algeria** has legislation requiring equal pay without discrimination. Algeria continues to experience occupational segregation, lack of salary transparency, and relatively high rates of unpaid care and high disparities in the large informal sectors of employment. Women struggle to get higher income earning opportunities.
2. **Argentina** mandates equal pay in its constitution and other laws, but the gap is still in practice. High rates of unpaid care for women may affect formal

employment rates, as well as gender bias increasing difficulty in employment and representation. Occupational segregation is also observed as women are typically employed in lower income jobs. The enforcement of equal pay is weak. Proposed 2026 labor reforms may negatively impact women's employment conditions as they weaken protections for workers who have long hours, modify work hours and severance pay, and restrict bargaining.

3. **Australia** mandates equal pay and enforces it through requiring pay transparency for employers 100+ employees to report gender pay data. Employers with 500+ employees have to set three gender equality targets over 3-year cycles and report progress to the Workplace Gender Equality Agency. Australia experiences gaps mainly due to persisting discrimination and occupation segregation. Australia is working to improve the gap through strengthening enforcement.
4. **Austria** mandates equal pay and requires employers with 150+ employees to internally audit gender pay data. Austria is working to publicly report pay data in the future.
5. **Bangladesh** experiences gender pay gaps due to occupational segregation, gender expectations, and a lack of equal pay law enforcement while having achieved an overall high gender parity score. Wage gaps are higher in peri-urban areas. The government mandates equal pay, however, and is working to improve gender income parity in upcoming legislation.
6. **Bosnia and Herzegovina** mandates equal pay without discrimination. However, women have significantly less labor force participation and occupational segregation. There is little to none enforcement of equal pay. BiH is working to improve women's pay.
7. **Brazil** mandates equal pay and active salary transparency for employers with over a hundred employees, requiring a biannual report publication, and reporting channels with correction action plans for report discrimination. Brazil experiences occupational segregation with women in lower-earning jobs. Traditional

expectations for women in domestic life limit practice and long-term commitment in the labor force. Brazil is looking to improve the gap.

8. **Canada** has legislation requiring equal pay, employers with 10 or more employees to provide a plan to achieve equal pay for equal-valued work, and a provision of updates on this plan every five years from those employers. Canada mainly experiences occupational segregation and discrimination. Canada is working to strengthen pay equity, but experiences potential funding cuts and implementation delays.
9. **Chad** experiences some of the world's greatest gender pay disparities. Chad does not have legislation mandating equal pay based on gender. Women are vulnerable to significantly lower earnings, and they have around 50% gender parity in the labor force. Chad does not have any pay gap targets looking into the future and no proactive equal pay mechanisms.
10. **China** experiences wage gaps in practice despite equal pay legislation. Women also experience gender bias in numbers of hours worked and progression in role levels. Private and rural sectors have larger gaps than public sectors. Restriction and penalties on marriage and motherhood further impact hiring and promotion of women. There is limited enforcement due to lack of mandated pay transparency, but China legally supports equal pay.
11. **Colombia** has various protections for pay equity within its legislation, with ongoing efforts to remove disparities in the workplace on the legal level. Despite this, there continues to be gaps in employment participation alongside salary. Women in rural areas or within the informal economy (which composes 55% of the workforce in the nation) especially face great hardship when it comes to fighting for their rights. Colombia, while making great strides in the legal sect of the issue, lacks when it comes to upholding those rights.

12. **Dominican Republic** presents high rates of female poverty and economic inequality, leading to lack of access to social security, gender-based violence, poor health *etc.* The nation itself has made great technical strides regarding gender equality, however women still face great structural challenges regarding the four sub-index dimensions.
13. **Democratic Republic of the Congo** currently has low levels of female participation in the labor market, especially wage employment, as well as large gaps in pay and/or profit. Gender equality in the DRC is trademarked by a lack of personal agency for women, with a majority of the decision-making being shared or entirely on the part of their husbands. There is an ongoing trend of men unconsciously using their wives' profits, preventing them from growing savings or investing it. Due to these factors, women are unempowered, vulnerable to economic shock, and unable to get out of these situations.
14. **Egypt** experiences ongoing occupational segregation stemming from a system that heavily relies on women working in low-paying sectors of the labor force. Female employment stays low and heavily concentrated in care-taking jobs with disregard to the improvements made to educational attainment. The lack of diversity and availability within Egypt's female labor force hinders progress in other areas.
15. **El Salvador** scores higher than the Latin-American average in regard to the life cycle of working women, with the pay gap being \$0.89 per dollar. There are still many gaps surrounding this issue, including a lower chance of women having bank accounts and higher rates of unpaid labor compared to men.
16. **France** has legislation requiring equal pay and for employers with a minimum of 50 employees to publish a pay gap indicator score. France mostly experiences underrepresentation of women in higher earning roles, but has high parity otherwise. Women face gaps most likely to discrimination. France has centralized minimum wage and is improving the gap.

17. **Germany** has legislation requiring equal pay and for employers with over 500 employees to have pay transparency. Women tend to work in lower paying sectors with occupational segregation and high part-time rates, experience slower promotions, and some discrimination.
18. **Ghana** mandates equal pay, however there is little enforcement or transparency. Women experience a high wage gap compared to men due to limited leverage in income bargaining, education gaps, informal sectors offering lower wages, and occupation segregation. Ghana is working to improve through support programs, budgeting, and new legislation.
19. **Honduras** mandates equal pay, but there is a lack of enforcement and required pay transparency. There have been recent enforcement mechanisms implemented, like standardized case inspections, however the applications are inconsistent, especially for informal sectors, and broader conditions. The gap is due to the high percentage of employment in informal economies for women limiting enforcement viability, education gaps, and cultural norms of bias. Honduras is looking to improve parity through initiatives, increased budgets, and partnerships.
20. **Iceland** is the first and only country to ban pay discrimination with fines if an employer with a minimum of 25 employees fails to certify every 3 years and prove equal pay. Notably, Iceland is ranked 1st out of 148 nations for the 16th consecutive year in the 2025 Global Gender Gap Report by the World Economic Forum.
21. **India** mandates equal pay but practices no enforcement or mandated transparency. The gap is primarily due to occupational segregation with women dominating informal sectors and lower earning jobs, cultural norms, low female labor force participation rates, and workplace biases. India is working on corporate initiatives, support programs, but there is little centralization.

22. **Iran** mandates equal pay but practices no enforcement or mandated transparency.

Iran has a high wage gap. Women experience severe gender discrimination in hiring, disproportionate to education rates. Women need the permission of their male guardian to work and travel—this limits job access. There are many restrictive cultural norms systemically and institutionally. These factors result in low labor force participation and higher numbers in lower earning, informal economies. The Iranian government is making minimal steps to improve gender pay equity. Various reforms and laws have been passed recently that have harmed women's participation in the economy. As the war with the United States begins, the nation can expect more economic issues, possibly worsening the gender pay gap.

23. **Italy** mandates equal pay and requires pay transparency and corrective actions on gaps over 5%. Women facing gaps would be mainly attributed to discrimination and norms. Italy is looking to improve gaps through strengthening transparency and reports.

24. **Japan** mandates equal pay and is expanding transparency for employers with 301+ employees to disclose gender pay gaps and management gender ratios. Japan experiences occupational segregation and underrepresentation of women in management roles. Japan is looking to improve the gap.

25. **Kazakhstan** mandates equal pay, however there is no enforcement or required reported transparency. Kazakhstan experiences pay inequity due to occupational segregation, glass ceilings in role levels for women, and cultural norms of prioritizing men's employment. Women are often in informal jobs. Kazakhstan is working to improve workplace discrimination and union rights, but is very gradual.

26. **Lebanon** mandates pay without gender-based discrimination, however enforcement stays weak during the current economic crisis. Women's labor force participation rate is much lower than men's due to cultural norms and the

economic crisis. Women also experience occupational segregation and are involved heavily in unpaid domestic work. There is no centralized pay transparency or data reporting. Lebanon shows limited support of pay equity.

27. **Mexico** mandates equal pay and fines for violations. Women experience occupational segregation and are in informal jobs lacking benefits, protections, and equitable pay. Mexico is looking to improve standardization and implement state-level bills to target gaps.
28. **Mongolia** mandates equal pay, but there are no active enforcement or transparency mechanisms. Women experience occupational segregation, are involved in unpaid care work, and are pressured by patriarchal societal norms. Mongolia is in support of gender pay equity, but has limited active action.
29. **Myanmar** mandates equal pay but has weak enforcement due to civil conflict and limited labor inspections. Women are involved in unpaid care work and the effects of the economic crisis are dire. Myanmar is working for minimum wage improvements, but there is little progress on women-specific reforms.
30. **Namibia** mandates equal pay, but there are no enforcement mechanisms or required reporting. Women are unpaid for caregiving and experience discrimination and occupational segregation. Namibia is focused on higher participation in the labor force and less on wage audits.
31. **North Korea** mandates equal pay, but there are no enforcements or required auditing. Women dominate the black markets and face discrimination despite being the primary earners. North Korea is not a member of the International Labor Organization and is not prioritized on rights or addressing gender disparity.
32. **Pakistan** mandates equal pay, however, enforcement is weak. The wage gap stems from low labor force participation of women and occupational segregation. Women are often employed in informal work, where gaps heighten. Pakistan is working to improve pay transparency and reporting.

33. **Papua New Guinea** mandates but enforcement is weak with no mandatory audits or transparency. Women face gaps due to occupational segregation and cultural barriers. Papua New Guinea has been working to increase the number of jobs available.
34. **Peru** struggles with gender equality in the workplace, with women being less likely to work full time for pay and having 21 less hours a week of paid work than men. There are additionally large disparities in labor force participation surrounding motherhood due to lack of childcare resources. Peru's adherence to strict gender roles hinders its ability to make forward progress.
35. **The Philippines** is considered a leader of gender equality in Southeast Asia, being ranked 20 on the Global Gender Gap Report. The nation has taken many strides to close this gap through implementing progressive policy and law, yet continue to face issues regarding female representation in public and private sector leadership and lower wages for comparable work.
36. **Poland** has one of the lowest gender pay gaps and has large female representation in leadership roles. They continue to implement national law & policy, currently looking to tackle issues regarding disparities in education, job opportunities, and working experience.
37. **Romania** has one of the lowest gender pay gap in Europe, and has had slight annual decreases in their gender pay gap over the past few years. Looking at national trends, women tend to have lower-paying jobs and make up a majority of the lower-paying quartile while men receive 19% higher bonuses and dominate the highest paying quartile.
38. **Russia** is struggling with a spike in their gender pay gap, approaching 50%, which has not been seen since 2005. The nation is currently under financial distress due to the Ukraine war, causing the decreasing trend of the past two decades to become undone.

- 39. Rwanda** currently has a gender pay gap of 26% hourly and 39% annually, with the difference between the two stemming from the fact that women work less hours than men on average. Disparities in education force women into lower-paying jobs, and marital status affects pay.
- 40. Senegal** continues to struggle with fully closing the pay gap, with wage inequality varying across different jobs. Labor force participation remains the largest issue for the nation, while issues regarding discrimination in the workforce and difference in endowment contribute greatly to said participation gap.
- 41. Slovenia** has one of the lowest global income gaps, and has made great progress on the legal/political level. This, however, has not exactly translated into the workforce, with there continuing to be issues with participation.
- 42. Solomon Islands** continues to include a legal framework to lessen the gender pay gap, however, this effort is weakened by the continuing systematic problems faced by women. Issues of unequal access to education, unfair social burdens, and discrimination within financial services persist, hindering any potential progress at closing the gap.
- 43. Somalia** has undergone much transformation in the labor market, yet still shows inequalities related to gender. The low levels of female participation can be attributed to the fact that women make up most of the informal and poor sectors of the workforce, while issues with economic potential can be found within the legal framework of the nation.
- 44. South Africa** has multiple standards held against women that prevent the gender pay gap from closing. Despite recent pushes for increased equality, gender inequality remains high.

Questions to Consider

Here are some questions to help guide you in conference speeches and our collaborative investigation together.

1. How significant is the gender pay gap in your nation? How does this impact other aspects of your nation? Are there any motives driving or stopping action on the pay gap?
2. Does your country already have legislation addressing the pay gap? What succeeded? What failed?
3. What are some predicted effects of equal pay? Economically, socially, or politically?
4. How do we support women of varying identities so that their respective needs are met? How do we define this act so that it respects and offers equitable help to different economic and sociopolitical states of various nations?
5. How should we address and approach our committee's funding and influence on governing bodies? Our committee offers many services to Member States, yet where do we draw the line? How do we continue to be relevant, and therefore need and receive funding?

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